

Final Reflection

Qualitative Research

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Reflecting on what I have learned about qualitative research, I can say that I know more about the subject now than before. I always knew that qualitative research involved interviews. I just did not know about the process used in qualitative research. I know now that qualitative data is derived from the interview process. The interview process and transcribing the interview into text data are easy parts of qualitative research. The difficult part of the process is qualitative data analysis. To interpret qualitative data, you map interview themes into codes, and from these codes, the researcher interprets the meaning of the code(s). The subject is complex because it involves perceptually piecing together information to form an interpretation.

First, I have conducted a successful miniature qualitative study on *Successful African American Professionals*. Second, I have learned about various qualitative processes such as Phenomenology, Ethnography, Case Study, and Grounded Theory. I have referred to these theories as the process, meaning the process in qualitative research. I believe that it is more of a process than a theory. I guess you could also call it a theory, since it is based on the three branches of philosophy. Third, I have learned about Computer-Assisted Qualitative Data Analysis Software (CAQDAS). I have investigated NVivo 7 from QRS International. If there is one thing that I like about qualitative research, it has to be CAQDAS. My skills in this area are unmatched by anyone in the group. I am not only a user but also a designer of this kind of software. The meaning of numbers, concept maps, and relating things (i.e., codes) is what I do every day at work, which is problem solving by concept map and by relating one related thing (i.e., object) to another thing (i.e., objects). I have become familiar with qualitative methods after using NVivo 7. NVivo 7, like all other qualitative software tools I have looked at, is

conceptually similar. Qualitative data analysis involves relating themes to codes and drawing conclusions. And these are the things that I do every day at work. This type of problem-solving is in my nature.

Although I like qualitative research and am sure to use some part of it in the future, maybe a combination of both qualitative and quantitative research. I think that there will be times when you have to use both. Nevertheless, I still like qualitative research more for a couple of reasons: 1) dealing with numbers; 2) more empirical; 3) statistics; 4) math; and 5) making sense of numbers. I believe that this is true research, because the meanings of numbers are universal. However, the nature of humans and their behaviors makes it hard to predict with just numbers. Qualitative research involves an in-depth understanding of human behavior and the reasons that govern human behavior.

All in all, I have learned what I needed for the Comprehensive Exams. I passed the research question. I believe that quantitative research is what puts me over the top. I am much more confident about quantitative research than qualitative research. Even with qualitative research, I knew exactly what I had to do. I am just seemingly following the process.